

Agent foregrounding and the conditioning of P-argument expression: qualitative and quantitative observations

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Abstract

This paper examines agent foregrounding constructions in Northern Chaco Mocoví and their effects on the expression of P arguments. Building on a description of clause types and argument expression, the analysis focuses on the derivational markers *-gan* and *-takan*, which combine detransitivizing and causativizing functions. When used as intransitivizers, these markers increase the prominence of the agent and demote the P argument, giving rise to a set of constructions functionally comparable to antipassives. Based on both elicited and natural discourse data, the study identifies the morphosyntactic correlates of P-argument demotion, the conditions under which P arguments may or may not be expressed, and the discourse strategies used to reintroduce them. The paper also shows that the detransitivized forms play a central role in lexicon building, especially in the formation of derived nouns. A quantitative case study complements the qualitative analysis by illustrating the distribution of agent foregrounding and morphologically related constructions in natural speech. The findings contribute to understanding valence alternation, argument expression, and lexical derivation in Mocoví and to broader typological discussions on antipassive-related phenomena.

Keywords: agent foregrounding, P-demotion, Northern Chaco Mocoví, lexical distribution, frequency

1 Introduction

This paper examines the morphosyntactic and discourse properties of agent foregrounding constructions in Northern Chaco Mocoví. These constructions arise through the use

of the derivational markers *-gan* and *-takan*, which participate in a broader system of valence-changing morphology. When used as detransitivizers, these markers reduce the verbal valence of two-place predicates and highlight the agent's activity, contributing in the demotion or omission of the P argument. Because this function overlaps with properties commonly associated with antipassive constructions, the analysis also draws on recent typological work on antipassives to contextualize the Mocoví patterns.

The study first describes the relevant clause types and the mechanisms by which Mocoví expresses core arguments. Particular attention is given to the role of nominal determiners, the interaction between verb morphology and argument structure, and the conditions that license or block the expression of the P argument. The paper then explores how the detransitivizing use of *-gan* and *-takan* affects the presence, form, and interpretation of the P argument, especially in relation to definiteness, referentiality, and argument indexing.

Based on elicited data and natural discourse, the analysis identifies several strategies for recovering or reintroducing the P argument after demotion, including multiverbal sequences and oblique-marked participants. The distribution of these strategies is examined in relation to verb valence, predicate semantics, and narrative context. Additionally, the paper shows that detransitivized predicates play an important role in lexicon building, serving as bases for derived nouns formed through the nominalizer *-cak*.

A small case-study based on a narrative text provides a first quantitative perspective on the frequency and discourse behavior of these constructions. Although agent foregrounding predicates occur relatively infrequently in discourse, their distribution is systematic and reflects functional motivations related to participant tracking and event structure. Overall, the study contributes to understanding how Mocoví organizes valence alternation, argument prominence, and lexical derivation within its verbal system.

2 The Mocoví people and their language

Mocoví is part of the Guaycuruan family along with other four languages, three of which are still spoken today, i.e., Kadiwéó, Toba and Pilagá. Mocoví communities are located in northeastern Argentina, as shown in Map 1¹ They are spread out across two neighboring provinces, Chaco and Santa Fe, creating a chain of geographically connected clusters of Mocoví families.

¹Personal elaboration based on the name of Mocoví communities as reported in different studies on Mocoví language and culture; see among others, Altman (2010, 2011), Carrió (2009), Dalla-Corte Caballero (2012), Gualdieri (1998), Grondona (1998), Iparraguirre (2011, 2016), López (2017).

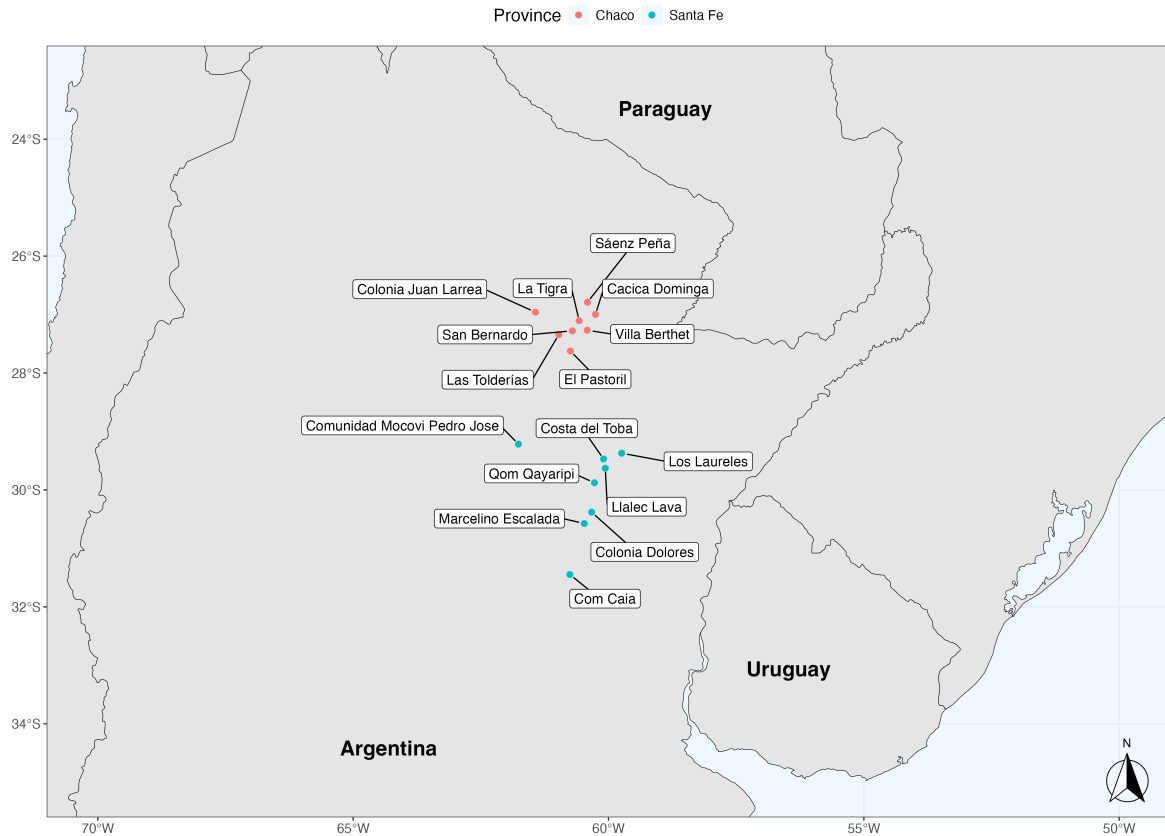


Figure 1: Mocoví communities in the Argentine Gran Chaco.

Demographically, as one moves further north within the chain of Mocoví communities, it becomes increasingly common to find families that have been in contact with Toba-speaking communities for over a century or more. This is the case, for example, in the community Cacica Dominga in Colonia Aborigen, which marks one of the northernmost points of the Mocoví community chain in Argentina. Here, Mocoví and Toba families have been in a long-term and intense contact, fostering a complex social organization that also integrates non-indigenous people. The specific social and linguistic outcomes of this long-term contact situation are still in need of further research.

Data included in this study mostly come from what I call Northern Chaco Mocoví, which corresponds to the language as spoken in the rural area of Colonia Aborigen (e.g., Cacica Dominga), and has been subject of a long-term documentation project since 2011 (see Juárez 2019). The large corpora included here deals with controlled and natural speech data collected originally via fieldwork. Northern Chaco Mocoví data include a basic metadata information indicating date of collection and location of the example in the audio-video files e.g., (mocCA160720_1: 00:31:19). When examples come from a source other than my

own collection, this information is also provided in parenthesis for the specific illustration. See also [section 7](#) to know more about the accompanying documentation of this paper, i.e., repository and access to raw data.

2.1 Morphosyntactic language profile

This section deals with basic clause types, showing the typical valence-type predicates and the expression their core arguments. The semantic and structural criterion for clause categorization will be relevant to identify the P-demotion effect and sets the annotation schema followed in [section 5](#). Structurally, the verb complex includes the following morphological elements detailed in [Figure 2](#). Relevant for the following discussion are valence modifiers in positions 1 and 2.

-3	-2	-1	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13
NEG-	SUBJ.DEF-	B.FORM-	VERB	-VM I	-VM II	-B.FORM	-BEN/-TRVZ	-ASP	-DES	-REFL/-RECP	-LOC	-DIR	TRVZ	-NON.SBJ.PL	=DIM	=EVD/TPRL?
sV-	qa-	Set I-	ROOT	-cat	-it	-Set I	-m	-ta	-ake	-ta?	-lek	-wek	-a(?a)	-lo	=oki?	=o?
		Set II-		-can	-can	-Set II	-a(?a)	-sa		-lta?	-ge	-figem			=o?i?	
		Set III-		-takan	-takan	-Set III		-tak			-gi	-o				
								-sak			-git	-ji				
								-teg								

Figure 2: Northern Chaco Mocoví verb structure.

Following a traditional view on clause classification, here I define types of clauses by the valence profile of their predicates ([Dryer 2007](#), [Mithun 2005a,b](#)) and their (morpho)syntactic patterning. This latter feature is in turn recognized by the way in which arguments are treated with respect to verb indexing, word order and oblique flagging. (see [Comrie et al. 2015](#): 3-4). The (morpho-)syntactic pattern of a clause will then serve to recognize clause types such as intransitive and transitive clauses, among other language-specific subtypes. From a typological angle, it is often mentioned that certain classes of predicates are taken to be present in almost all languages, namely mono-valent and bi-valent predicates, whereas other types of predicates are subject to more language-specific variation, e.g. avalent predicates ([Malchukov et al. 2010](#)). Mocoví, and to a large extent its Guaycuruan sister languages, is distinctive in that predicates are lexically categorized as either mono-valent or bi-valent and that these predicate fall into different morphosyntactic patterns. Arguments, in turn, are defined by the the number of semantic participants required by the predicate and their specific morphosyntactic expression to form a grammatical clause ([Song 2015](#)). In what follows, we will see that both verb valence and morphosyntactic encoding

98 of participants work together to recognize core arguments.

99 2.2 Argument expression and clause types

100 Let us begin with typical one-place predicates. Examples of this type of predicate are *-oʔon*
101 ‘get married’ or *-inta* ‘be similar’ in (1) and they require a single participant. The main
102 expression of this participant is the bound person form, i.e., *s-*, which encodes the syntactic
103 function S. Commonly, co-nominals or pronominal elements of S arguments tend to be
104 overt only for referent identification. Less relevant for this paper are verbless or non-verbal
105 clauses like *jim coratom*, where the juxtaposition of elements suffice for a predication.

106 (1) One-place predicate clause

107 *s-oʔon qam qajka ka s-inta jim cora-ta-om*
1.I-get_married but EXIST.NEG DET₁ 1.II-be_similar 1.SG.PRON be_poor-DUR-INTS

108 ‘... I got married, but I was not the same, I was very poor...’

109 (mocCA190924_1: 00:02:20)

110 Two-place predicates are like (2) and (3), which require two participants, semanti-
111 cally categorized as agent-like and patient-like respectively, and are morphosyntactically
112 expressed in different ways. The A argument is verb-indexed and the P argument is overtly
113 expressed by an independent pronoun or nominals. Syntactically, P arguments tend to
114 precede the predicate when they correspond to speech act participants. On the contrary,
115 third-person P arguments follow the verb and their co-nominal or pronominal expression
116 are expressed as in (3a-3b).

117 (2) Basic two-place predicate clause: 2nd person P

118 *qamir s-alawat-ɕ qamir s-aʔgin-ɕ*
2SG.PRON 1.II-kill-PL 2SG.PRON 1.II-eat-PL

119 ‘...we are going to kill you and we are going to eat you...’ (mocCA191025: 00:38:33)

120 (3) Basic two-place predicate clauses: 3rd person P

121 a. *s-oʔkowan-tak na isigijak*
1.I-chase-PROG DET₃ animal

122 ‘... I (usually) was chasing animals...’ (mocCA191022_2: 00:03:10)

123 b. *s-agan-pi so i-ocon-a n-etfikse*
1.I-leave.alone-DIR:DOWN DET₂ 1.POSS-take-NMLZ.OBJ.F INDET.POSS-lizard

124 ‘...I left alone my prey, the lizard...’ (mocCA191022_2: 00:03:36)

In addition to the transitive and intransitive basic clauses, there are other different clause types, defined by with what I call here extended arguments (the terminology is inspired by Dixon & Aikhenvald 2000: 3-4). In these cases, both basic one-place and two-place predicates can take an specific type of spatial morphology or other suffixes expressing P arguments. The spatial morphology class, in particular, includes the locative-orientative suffixes, which can express not only topological information but also work similar to what is typologically defined as applicative morphology (for an updated discussion of earlier and more recent descriptions of spatial morphology, see Juárez 2025). Observe the contrast in (4), where the presence of the locative-orientative *-ge* with a one-place predicate allows the expression of a participant that could otherwise be included as an oblique-marked nominal. Predicates like these in (4b) deviate from the typical one-place predicates in that the addition of spatial morphology calls for an (otherwise) peripheral participant – namely, a location that is semantically not required by the verb valence – as a P argument, whose nominal expression is similar to those in (3) above. Thus, in clauses of this type, the argument extension is noted by the additional verb marking that implies a new P argument and by the non-oblique expression of the implied participant. It should also be noted that predicates of this kind are by default categorized as one-place predicates, hence the intransitive glossing for the original S argument of the basic clause is maintained.

(4) Extended one-place predicate clause

- a. *qomir qar-oʔtʃi (ke-na nadzik)*
 1PL.PRON 1.PL.I.INTR-be_afraid OBL-DET₃ track
 ‘We are afraid of that track’ (mocCA120706: 00:50:42)
- b. *qomir qar-oʔtʃi-ge (*ke)-na nadzik*
 1PL.PRON 1.PL.I.INTR-be_afraid-LOC₃ OBL-DET₃ track
 ‘We fear that track’ (mocCA120706: 00:51:34)

Building on the morphosyntactic evidence presented in (4), cases like (5), which includes a movement predicate, also fall within the domain of extended one-place predicates. Additionally, predicates of this type contrast with semantically similar predicates of the kind in (6). Unlike predicates with locative-orientative markers, one-place predicates including directional morphology naturally occur with a peripheral locative participant expressed as an oblique.

(5) Extended one-place predicate clause

- t-a-ge na ʔo:tʃi ken ʔwe ka-ta n-akit-gak*
 3.II.INTR-go-LOC₃ DET₁ forest ADV EXIST DET₅-? 3.INDET.POSS-hope-NMLZ
n-akit-take l-oq
 3.INDET.POSS-hope-DES 3.POSS-food

157 ‘...she usually went to the forest hoping to receive food...’

158 (mocCA191010_1: 00:02:48)

159 (6) *qamir k-ir-figem ke-na qopaq*
2SG.PRON move-2.SG.II-DIR:UP OBL-DET₃ tree

160 ‘Did you climb the tree?’ (mocCA120717: 00:36:28)

161 As mentioned before, two-place predicates can also combine with locative-orientative
162 morphology or other suffixes to express P arguments. The effect that locative-directional
163 suffixes have on two-place predicates varies, as these suffixes can simply provide spatial
164 information regarding the P argument or actually extend the number of arguments. Other
165 suffixes expressing a P argument merely serve to indicate the presence of such argument,
166 indexing non-singular number of the P argument. The chain of clauses in (7) illustrates the
167 use of both P argument expressing morphology. Here the speaker narrates about his past
168 hunting experience and what kind of animals he used to hunt; in this context, the connected
169 clauses should be viewed as statements about general, recurring, former events.

170 On the one hand, the locative-orientative suffix *-git* entails that the P argument is
171 coming to the A argument and contributes to the change in meaning of the verb root i.e.
172 SEE → FIND. Strictly speaking, there is no addition of a new argument via the spatial marker
173 (as with one-place predicates), but rather a semantic elaboration on how the P argument
174 interacts with the A. On the other hand, the sequence *a-lo* simply expresses the multiplicity
175 of entities in the reference of the P nominal. Although both instances of the nominal
176 ‘lizard’ do not receive any plural marking, the verb morphology indicating non-singular
177 referentiality contribute to establish the number contrast given in the translation.²

178 (7) Extended two-place predicates

179 *s-akon-ta-a-lo na filqajk-qa p-awan-git a-na n-tfikse*
1.II-take-DUR-ARG-ARG.PL DET₃ otter-PL 1.III-see-LOC₃ F-DET₃ INDET.POSS-lizard
180 *s-akon-ta-a-lo na tfikse*
1.II-take-DUR-ARG-ARG.PL DET₃ lizard

²To better understand the English translation offered in (7), the semantic distinction between *kind-referring* and *object-referring* terms can be particularly helpful. There is a large discussion in the field of semantics on these terms – which is part of a topic far beyond the scope of this paper –, thus, here I follow ideas in Krifka et al. (1995). The use of *ana ntfikse* with the predicate *pawangit* appears to be of the *kind-referring* expression, as the reference is not to the specific animal, but the genus ‘lizard’. By contrast, the second use of the same nominal with the predicate *sakontaalo* is *object-referring* in the sense that reference narrow down to the specific animals contained in the *kind*. Additionally, consider that natural discourse usually shows unconditioned variation in gender and number expression in nominals. Thus, the second use of *na tfikse* should not be interpreted as referring to a single, indentifiable ‘lizard’, but rather to many of them (see also Krifka 2025)

181 ‘...(back then when I hunt) I took otters, I found (a) lizard and I took the lizards...’
 182 (mocCA190924_1: 00:03:30)

183 Natural discourse examples presented in this section show that while the S and A ar-
 184 guments are invariably indexed in the verb complex, the overt realization of a P argument
 185 can be either only nominal or pronominal, or can be co-expressed by verbal morphology
 186 and its corresponding nominal or pronominal expression. This argument expression vari-
 187 ability is relevant for the data annotation and is implemented for capturing the range of
 188 possibilities for expressing P argument in discourse.

189 2.3 The expression of P arguments: nominal determiners and their uses

190 A key feature of the nominal expression of core arguments involves the preceding nominal
 191 determiner.³ The closed class of six nominal determiners encodes different semantic pa-
 192 rameters related to the nominal referent and can be selected on speech context basis. As a
 193 whole, the clustering of semantic parameters in the paradigm of nominal determiners rep-
 194 resents a salient typological feature of the nominal domain (cf. Aikhenvald 2000: 178-181).
 195 These semantic features include presence vs. absence, position (lying, standing or sitting)
 196 and movement/proximity (coming to the speaker or away from the speaker).

Table 2: Northern Chaco Mocoví nominal determiners.

SEMANTIC DIMENSIONS		DETERMINER	FULL GLOSS
Absence		<i>ka</i>	DET ₁ : non-visible, absent
Presence	Movement	<i>so</i>	DET ₂ : going, far
		<i>na</i>	DET ₃ : coming, close
	Position	<i>ra</i>	DET ₄ : static, vertical
		<i>dzi</i>	DET ₅ : static, horizontal
		<i>pi</i>	DET ₆ : static, sitting

197 In addition to the semantic features mentioned above, nominal determiners con-
 198 tribute to the definiteness of nominal referents. In this regards, defined and highly identifi-
 199 able nouns follow nominal determiners, as in (8). Furthermore, the selection of determiners

³These grammatical elements have been referred to differently in the previous studies on Mocoví and the other Guaycuruan languages. They are labelled ‘classifiers’ in Pilagá (Vidal 2001: 112-113, Payne & Vidal 2020) and ‘demonstratives’ in Toba (Censabella 2002: 147-149) and Kadiwéó (Sandalo 1997: 61-63). In Mocoví specifically, the labels of ‘deictic roots’ (? : 79), ‘classifiers’ (?) and ‘demonstratives’ (?) have been used to refer to what I call determiners here.

200 does not seem to obey exclusively to the semantic properties of the nominal referent, as
 201 discourse factors also appear to play a role. Note in the example below, for example, that
 202 the selection of the nominal determiner could have been *pi*, as referents of this kind are
 203 commonly conceived in a sitting position. Instead, the speaker selected *ka*, which encodes
 204 absence of the referent. This nominal determiner fits the discourse context, however, as the
 205 speaker narrates events from a remote past, i.e., childhood, which naturally implies that the
 206 nominal referent is not present at the moment of speech.

- 207 (8) *sa-s-awan-qa-pe-ge-a ka mala?*
 NEG-1.II-see-PL-PROG-LOC₃-OBJ.ARG DET₁ bed
 208 ‘...we didn’t know the bed...’ (mocCA191122_2: 00:01:48)

209 However, depending on the referent and, to some extent on the predicate type, nom-
 210 inal determiners can be omitted, which also affects the referential properties of the noun.
 211 Example (9) shows that the noun *to:rta* occurs without a nominal determiner in the eat-
 212 ing event. The reference here is not to a single entity, but to multiple entities, which is
 213 reinforced by the dinamicity of the eating event in its progressive form. Change in the
 214 referentiality of determined and undetermined nouns is more obvious if we compare the
 215 expression of A and P arguments. Whereas the former occurs with the determiner *so* and
 216 the referent is a single, individualized entity, the latter lacks a determiner and its referen-
 217 tiality is less individualized.

- 218 (9) *so recat Ø-ke?e-tak to:rta_{sp} kemar-aca-j*
 DET₂ jaguar 3II-eat-PROG bread be_full-NMLZ-ATTR-F
 219 ‘...(they say that) the jaguar was eating fried bread and got full...’
 220 (mocCA191127_2: 00:09:18)

221 Lastly, it is worth mentioning that nominal determiners have a broader range of uses
 222 and constitute one of the devices available in the language for discourse linking. Of par-
 223 ticular relevance for this work is their clause-combining function, where they introduce
 224 a noun-modifying clause similar to relative clauses. This property of nominal determiner
 225 is not exclusive to Mocoví, as it has also been reported for other Guaycuruan languages
 226 (Gualdieri 1998: 114-115; for an overview on Toba relative clauses, see Carpio & Censabella
 227 2012, Messineo & Porta 2009). In (10), for example, the nominal determiner *so* introduces
 228 the extended one-place predicate. This clause modifies the P argument, which in turn ex-
 229 presses a locative role within the modifying clause (see also 28 where a nominal determiner
 230 introduces an object complement-like clause).

231 (10) *eko s-ole:nta-g-tak n-o?Gor-ik so*
 232 *DISC 1.II-remember-PL-PROG INDET.POSS-be_poor-NMLZ.OBJ.SG DET₂*
 233 *s-at/fikqo-ta-ge*
 234 *1.III-descend.PL-DUR-LOC₃*
 235 ‘...we are thinking about the poverty from where we are coming...’
 236 (mocCA190924_1: 00:02:08)

235 Examples like (10) illustrate the complexity involved in the expression of P arguments
 236 in natural speech. In these constructions, the same nominal is shared by the combined
 237 clauses. In the two-place predicate, predicate the P argument is only expressed lexically,
 238 whereas in the extended one-place predicate, the P argument is morphologically encoded,
 239 referring back to its co-nominal in the main clause.

240 3 Agent foregrounding in the context of valence alterna- 241 tions

242 After reviewing the morphosyntactic properties of argument expression, we now turn to
 243 the means by which P arguments can be demoted. We focus here on derivational elements
 244 *-gan* and *-ta:gan*, which occur in positions 1 and 2 in Figure 2. Such an derivational ele-
 245 ments can increase and decrease verb valence, creating constructions that fall within the
 246 domains of causativization and antipassivization. In other words, these dedicated valence
 247 modifiers primarily trigger changes in the morphosyntactic expression of S and A argu-
 248 ments, which naturally affects semantic and morphosyntactic properties of P arguments.
 249 The typologically unusual co-expression pattern has been studied by scholars working on
 250 Mocoví (Carrió 2015a,b, Juárez & Álvarez-González 2017, 2021) and is attested in other
 251 Guaycuruan languages as well. Cross-linguistically, only a handful of languages – not more
 252 than five languages, including Mocoví – have been reported to display this specific valence
 253 co-expression pattern (see Bahrt 2021: 100-103)⁴.

254 When *-gan* and *-ta:gan* function as intransitivizing devices, the resulting derived pred-
 255 icates are part of what I call agent foregrounding constructions. These stand in contrast to
 256 the subject defocusing construction, whose dedicated marker is *qa-* and occurs in position
 257 -2. Inspired by the framework on passives and related constructions in Shibatani (1985), I
 258 use the notions of foregrounding and defocusing as functional umbrella terms, indicating
 259 that subject and agent-like arguments either increase or decrease their discourse promi-

⁴However, this study fails to report several additional languages from the Gran Chaco region where this phenomenon is also attested

nence. Functionally, foregrounding and defocusing constructions mirror each other with respect to the effect that they have on the subject argument of these constructions.

xIn agent foregrounding constructions, specifically, the agent-like argument becomes structurally and discursively highly prominent. A by product of such a change in argument prominence is the demotion of the P argument, which structurally manifests in different ways, as we will see below (see 3.1). An example of an agent foregrounding construction is given in (11). In this example, the first use of the predicate *kill* inflects intransitively and the entailed P argument is syntactically omitted. The predication is only about the agent's activity and does not specify a clear, bounded outcome.

(11) *-gan* agent foregrounding construction

so pjoq i-ta:-ta?-pe-ge so ʎik so jale r-lawat-**gan**
 DET₂ dog 3.II-sniff-PL-PROG-LOC₂ DET₂ track DET₂ man 3.II.INTR-kill-VM:INTR
 i-lawat a-so una_{sp} neketegegaj
 3.II-kill F-DET₂ DET girl

‘The dog was sniffing the track of the killer (who) killed the girl.’

(mocCA130614_1: 00:09:42)

Furthermore, the agent foregrounding construction is both structurally and semantically connected to causative constructions, as illustrated in (12). Morphologically, only a small class of one-place predicates can be causativized by *-gan*, which introduces a cause participant, functioning as the A argument. This causativization process typically requires the bound person form *i-*, which indexes third-person, transitive subjects. Semantically, both the agent foregrounding and the causative constructions involve an agent-like argument that functions either as S (in the detransitivized clause) or A (in the causative clause) (see Juárez 2023: Ch.4)

(12) *-gan* causative construction

so jacat i-ʎgen-**gan**-pi pi i:mek
 DET₂ rain 3.II-fall-VM:TR-DIR:DOWN DET₆ house

‘The rain knocked down the house.’ (mocCA160720: 00:03:39)

On the other hand, agent foregrounding constructions functionally contrast with the subject-defocusing construction, illustrated in (13). In this construction, the subject is expressed as a non-referential, impersonal-like participant (e.g., someone, they, people) or as a plural participant, and only the P argument is discursively prominent. This clause does not inflect intransitively and its reading(s) is context dependent, always entailing a non-specific subject argument.

291 (13) Subject defocusing

292 *dʲo: dʒi i-wa qa-i-lawat qa-i-lawat dʒi i-wa*
EXCLAM DET₅ 1SG.POSS-wife SBJ.DEFC-3.II-kill SBJ.DEFC-3.II-kill DET₅ 1SG.POSS-wife

293 ‘...oh, someone killed my wife, someone killed my wife...’

294 (mocCA191127_2: 00:13:32)

295 3.1 Structural correlates and effects on the P argument

296 To understand the morphological and syntactic nuances of agent foregrounding construc-
297 tions, we begin by examining examples from controlled, elicited sentences. One of the
298 salient features of Mocoví is its person-based alignment pattern, combining nominative-
299 accusative and tripartite alignments. Thus, the structural correlates of the agent fore-
300 grounding constructions manifest slightly different whether the foregrounded A argument
301 corresponds to a speech act participant or to a non-speech act participant.

302 First- and second-person arguments follow a nominative-accusative alignment at the
303 indexing level – consider, for instance, A=S: s- ≠ P: Ø. Because of this alignment type, the
304 foregrounding effect on the subject argument does not correlate with any formal change
305 in its verbal expression. Foregrounding the A/S activity only leads to disregarding the
306 nominal determiner, as in (14a), therefore focusing on the verb action itself rather than
307 on its outcome. Consequently, the meaning of the verb also differs slightly from the base,
308 unmarked transitive construction. The entailment in (14b), is that the agent has not killed
309 a pig yet, but he is about to go somewhere else to engage in that specific activity, without
310 knowing whether the number of killed animals will be one or several.

311 (14) a. *ajim s-alawat so kos*
1SG.PRON 1.II-kill DET₂ pig

312 ‘I killed the pig.’ (mocCA160725: 00:35:22)

313 b. *ajim s-alawat-gan kos*
1SG.PRON 1.II-kill-VM:INTR pig

314 ‘I’m going to slaughter (a) pig(s).’ (mocCA160725: 00:35:22)

315 As mentioned above, when two-place predicates are marked by *-gan* and the A ar-
316 gument corresponds to a non-speech act participant, these predicates usually call for the
317 bound person *ɾ-*, which indicates an intransitive subject. In addition, the P argument can
318 be fully omitted (15b) or expressed as a bear noun without a nominal determiner (15c). In
319 both cases, the demoted P argument is interpreted as generic, lacking a sense of uniqueness,
320 although subtle semantic differences remain. In these examples, the complete omission of

the P argument allows for a much wider set of entities that could potentially be tied up, e.g., horses, cows, sheep, and the like, and only contextual clues can help identify the specific entities involved in this event. By contrast, the use of a bare noun narrows the possible referents to a specific class, in this case *horses*.

- (15) a. *so jale n-qoin so fipecac*
 DET₂ man 3.III-tie.up DET₂ horse
 ‘The man tied up a horse.’ (mocCA160725_1: 00:20:47)
- b. *so jale r-oqoin-gan*
 DET₂ man 3.II.INTR-tie.up-VM:INTR
 ‘The man goes to tie up (horses).’ (mocCA160725_1: 00:28:09)
- c. *r-oqoin-gan fipecac*
 3.II.INTR-tie.up-VM:INTR horse
 ‘He goes to tie up horses.’ (mocCA160725_1: 00:30:25)

In *gan*-marked two-place predicates, the expression of P arguments preceded by a nominal determiner results in ungrammatical clauses, regardless of whether the referential noun is singular (16a) or non-singular (16b), indicated by plural and collective morphology.⁵

- 334 (16) a. * *so jale r-qoin-gan so fipeq*
 335 *DET₂ man 3.III-tie.up-VM:INTR DET₂ horse*
 336 ‘The man goes to tie up the horse.’
 337 (mocCA160725_1: 00:29:01, rejected clause)
- 337 b. * *r-qoin-gan so fipeq-r-pi*
 338 *3.III-tie.up-VM:INTR DET₂ horse-PL-COLL*
 339 ‘He goes to tie up the horses.’
 340 (mocCA160725_1: 00:31:26, rejected clause)

Since this detransitivized construction requires a non-definite P argument, it naturally follows that its syntactic expression is ruled out when it refers to an individual, uniquely identifiable entity. Compare the derivation of the predicates (17) and (18). The causativized predicate allows the expression of the first-person singular P argument. However, when the clause is intransitivized by *-gan*, the construction becomes ungrammatical if the independent pronoun is expressed. Furthermore, note that the verb expression of the causee argument is also removed and the valence modifier occupies its slot.

⁵One would expect a clause like (16b) to be acceptable without the nominal determiner, but I could not test this specific context through elicitation. It should also be mentioned that natural discourse examples in my corpus do not include examples like (16) either.

- 347 (17) a. *so doqolek* *siempre_{sp} jim* *i-qopat-cat-it*
 348 *DET₂ non.indigenous(person) always 1SG.PRON 3.II-be.hungry-CAUS-CAUSEE*
 349 ‘The non-indigenous always makes me starve.’
 (mocCA191205: 00:13:39)
- 350 b. *so doqolek* *siempre_{sp} r-qopat-cat-gan*
 351 *DET₂ non.indigenous(person) always 3.INTR.II-be.hungry-CAUS-VM:INTR*
 352 ‘The non-indigenous (person) always makes (someone/people) starve.’
 (mocCA191205: 00:11:59)
- 353 (18) * *so doqolek* *siempre_{sp} ajim* *r-qopat-cat-gan*
 354 *DET₂ non.indigenous always 1SG.PRON 3.INTR.II-be.hungry-CAUS-VM:INTR*
 355 ‘The non-indigenous (person) always makes (me) starve.’
 (mocCA191205: 00:12:40, rejected clause)

356 3.2 How to recover the expression of P

357 Although agent foregrounding construction indirectly involve P demotion, the language
 358 displays several morphosyntactic strategies to overtly reintroduce the demoted argument
 359 and narrow its referentiality in the immediate discourse context. These syntactic strategies
 360 respond to the functional need of avoiding ambiguity in participant referentiality as the
 361 discourse unfolds, specifically regarding the erstwhile demoted P argument.

362 One of the strategies to encode the P argument of a detransitivized predicate is by the
 363 juxtaposition of two predicates that otherwise function as individual verbs on their own.
 364 This combination of predicates produces structures similar in many regards to serial verb
 365 constructions (see Aikhenvald 2006, Bisang 2009, Haspelmath 2016), although I do not treat
 366 them as a single complex clause here. The multiverbal strategy to encode the P argument of
 367 a detransitivized predicate can be further divided according to the valence of the combined
 368 predicates. On the one hand, we find combined predicates like *r-kin-gan* ‘She/He greets
 369 (somebody)’ and *i-kin* ‘She/He greets him/her’ in (19). This sequence of predicates involves
 370 then the *gan*-intransitivized predicate combined with a basic two-place predicate, creating
 371 a clause with the following transitivity pattern: INTR + TR.

- 372 (19) *Ø-k-pe-ge-e?* *r-kin-gan* *i-kin dži*
 373 *3.II-move-pe-LOC₂-PL 3.II.INTR-greet-VM:INTR 3.II-greet DET₅*
 374 *l-ja:le-qa-pi*
 375 *3.POSS-descendent-PL-COLL*
 ‘S/he goes to greet his/her children.’
 Lit. S/He goes, (S/he) greets, (S/he) greets his/her children.

Note that the selection of the second predicate does not appear to be arbitrary, as it repeats the same verb root, *-kin* ‘greet’, on which the *can*-intransitivized predicates is built. Thus, one could suggest that the greeting event depicted in the translation is made of two predications semantically connected by the shared verb meaning. While the first predication depicts the agentivity of the A argument, the second one helps to introduce the actual referent of the previously demoted P argument.

Another possibility to express the syntactically omitted P argument is illustrated in (20). Unlike (19), the first detransitivized predicate *-kin-can* is further derived by the stacking of *-gan* in its transitivizing function, which adds a new subject argument to the verb valency. This creates a morphologically complex predicate that combines with another non-derived two-place predicate. Both conjoined predicates show the following transitivity pattern: TR + TR. Like (19), the main function of the second predicate is the syntactic expression of the P argument that was part of the verb root employed in the double-derived predicate.

- (20) *ajim s-kin-can-can so i-ja:le-k i-kin so*
 1SG.PRON 1.II-greet-VM:INTR-VM:TR DET₂ 1SG.POSS-descendent-M 3.II-greet DET₂
l-pir
 3.POSS-grandfather

‘I made my son greet his grandfather.’ (mocCA160725: 00:46:37)

The set of examples above includes a derived verb root categorized as a two-place predicate in its basic non-derived use. The multiverb strategy to encode the omitted P argument is also possible if the verb root is of one-place. The main condition, however, is that the combined predicates adjust to one of the transitivity patterns already mentioned, specifically: INTR + TR. To achieve this syntactic pattern, the basic one-place predicate must be further derived. First, note that the *tagan*-intransitivized predicate does not accept the syntactic expression of P, as in (21a). But, in order to include it, the addition of the transitivized predicate *-tfil-gan* ‘shower him/her’ is needed (21b).

- (21) a. *r-tfil-gan-tagān* (*so qar-qaja-r-pi)
 3.III-shower-VM:TR-VM:INTR DET₂ 1PL.POSS-brother-PL-COLL
 ‘S/He baptizes (someone).’ (mocCA160726: 00:56:25)
- b. *r-atfel-gan-tagān-tak n-atfil-gan-tak so*
 3.III.INTR-shower-VM:TR-VM:INTR-PROG 3.III-shower-VM:TR-PROG DET₂
qar-qaja-r-pi i-nogon-o ke-ra
 1PL.POSS-brother-PL-COLL 3.II-enter-DIR:IN OBL-DET₄
n-qa:t-ek
 INDET.POSS-speak-SG.OBJ.NMLZ

407 ‘He is baptizing our brothers who joined the Word (of God).’
 408 Lit. ‘He is baptizing, (he) is baptizing our brothers, (they) went into the Word.’
 409 (mocCA160726: 00:46:37)

410 In the combined predicates like (19), (20), and (21b) the second predicate introducing
 411 the P argument appears to be lexically restricted to the same verb root that serves as the
 412 base for the *-can-* or *-takan-* detransitivized predicates.

413 Finally, another way to encode the former P argument of the detransitivized predi-
 414 cates is by marking it as an oblique, as illustrated in (22). This strategy is possible once the
 415 verb valence of the base predicate is re-augmented by *-can*, which results in the double-
 416 derived verb *-kin-can-can* ‘made to greet’. Rather than resulting in a clause with two non-
 417 subject arguments, this type of double derived predicate includes only two core arguments,
 418 the A and the P, in addition to the oblique-marked participant.

419 (22) *so i-taʔa ajim i-kin-can-can ke-so*
 DET₂ 1SG.POSS-father 1SG.PRON 3II-greet-VM:INTR-VM:TR OBL-DET₂
 420 *qar-pir*
 1PL.POSS-grandfather
 421 ‘My dad made me greet our grandfather.’ (mocCA160725: 01:01:22)

422 It must be mentioned, however, that examples like (22), are rather infrequent in nat-
 423 ural discourse, but naturally accepted when constructed via elicitation techniques. A much
 424 larger corpus-based study should elucidate the discourse factors playing a role in the selec-
 425 tion of either the oblique-marked expression of the demoted P argument or the multi-verbal
 426 strategy, with the demoted P as a core argument of the repeated verb root. This task is be-
 427 yond the scope of this paper.

428 4 Lexical distribution and importance for lexicon building

429 Since agent foregrounding constructions overlap in many respects with properties associ-
 430 ated with antipassive constructions, I draw on recent typological observations on antipas-
 431 sives to account for the distributional properties of the agent foregrounding morphological
 432 markers. Table 3 summarizes the distribution of the two-place predicates that occur with
 433 *-can* and *-takan*.

434 First, note that these elements exhibit complementary and asymmetric distributional
 435 patterns. Specifically, predicates that are detransitivized by *-can* do not occur with *-takan*,
 436 and vice versa. Additionally, the shorter form shows a much wider distribution than the
 437 longer form, which is restricted to only a handful of predicates. Furthermore, although

previous studies have not explicitly addressed the frequency of these suffixes, examples involving *-can* outnumber those with *-taġan* in the available linguistic descriptions of Mo-coví (see Carrió 2015a,b, Gualdieri 1998). Such an asymmetric distributional pattern is not unusual in languages that possess multiple antipassive marker (see, for instance, Janic & Witzlack-Makarevich 2021, Say 2021). Seržant et al. (2021), furthermore, argue that frequency plays a role in the asymmetric distribution of antipassive markers coexisting in the same language. Specifically, they propose that “the most frequent lexical input will correlate with the less marking on the verb and viceversa”.

Table 3: Two-place predicates taking *-can* and *-taġan* ‘VM:INTR’.

Two-place predicate		<i>can</i> -derived predicate	
<i>i-waġan</i>	‘S/he/it hits him/her/it’	<i>r-waġan-can</i>	‘S/he/it hits at (sth)’
<i>i-tfaġ</i>	‘S/he/it cuts him/her/it’	<i>r-tfaġ-can</i>	‘S/he goes to cut (sth)’
<i>i-kin</i>	‘S/he greets him/her’	<i>r-kin-can</i>	‘S/he/it greets (sb)’
<i>i-mit</i>	‘S/he/it searches for him/her/it’	<i>r-mit-can</i>	‘S/he/it searches around’
<i>i-lawat</i>	‘S/he/it kills him/her/it’	<i>r-lawat-can</i>	‘S/he goes to kill’
<i>i-ta:</i>	‘S/he/it smells’	<i>r-ta:-can</i>	‘S/he/it sniffs (around)’
<i>i-ra</i>	‘S/he writes sth.’	<i>r-ra-can</i>	‘S/he/it writes (sth)’
<i>i-?ġat</i>	‘S/he talks to him/her.’	<i>r-?ġat-can</i>	‘S/he talks’
<i>i-me:t</i>	‘S/he piles sth. up’	<i>r-me:t-can</i>	‘S/he piles up (sth)’
<i>i-lar</i>	‘S/he sends him/her’	<i>r-lat-can</i>	‘S/he gives orders’
<i>i-?le:nte</i>	‘S/he remembers him/her/it’	<i>r-?le:nte-can</i>	‘S/he remembers (sth)’
<i>i-lat</i>	‘S/he leaves him/her/it.’	<i>r-lat-can</i>	‘S/he leaves (sth/sb)’
<i>i-fila</i>	‘S/he asks him/her (sth)’	<i>r-fila-can</i>	‘S/he asks (sth)’
<i>i-nat</i>	‘S/he asks for sth.’	<i>r-nat-can</i>	‘S/he implores (him/her)’
<i>i-wale</i>	‘S/he borrows sth’	<i>r-wale-can</i>	‘S/he borrows (sth)’
<i>i-qawalat</i>	‘S/he kneads sth.’	<i>r-qawalat-can</i>	‘S/he kneads (sth)’
<i>n-qat</i>	‘S/he pulls sth. up’	<i>r-qat-can</i>	‘S/he goes to harvest’
<i>n-maren</i>	‘S/he scrapes sth’	<i>r-maren-can</i>	‘S/he goes to scrape (sth)’
<i>n-owar</i>	‘S/he sews sth’	<i>r-owar-can</i>	‘S/he sews (sth)’
$\emptyset$ -pelog	‘S/he rakes sth.’	<i>r-pelog-can</i>	‘S/he rakes (sth)’
$\emptyset$ -?leg	‘S/he sweeps sth.’	<i>r-?leg-can</i>	‘S/he sweeps (sth)’
$\emptyset$ -kijo	‘S/he washes sth.’	$\emptyset$ -kijo-can	‘S/he washes (sth)’
$\emptyset$ -lapon	‘S/he piles sth.’	$\emptyset$ -lapon-can	‘S/he piles (sth)’
		<i>taġan</i> -derived predicate	

Continued on next page

Table 3 – Continued from previous page

Two-place predicates		<i>gan</i> -derived predicate	
<i>i-pacagin</i>	‘S/he teaches him/her’	<i>r-pacagin-tagan</i>	‘S/he teaches (sth)’
<i>i-?den</i>	‘S/he knows sth.’	<i>r-?den-tagan</i>	‘S/he knows (sth)’
<i>n-taren</i>	‘S/he cures him/her’	<i>n-taren-tagan</i>	‘S/he cures (sb)’
<i>n-o?wen</i>	‘S/he works on sth.’	<i>r-o?wen-tagan</i>	‘S/he works’

446

447 Second, as far as I am aware, the only lexical constraint conditioning which predicates
448 can occur in agent foregrounding constructions relates to their basic verb valence. From
449 the verb list above and natural discourse data, it becomes clear that the relevant parameter
450 is that the base predicate must be a two-place predicate. In fact, the use of *-gan* and *-*
451 *tagan* as detransitivizers is a natural language-specific morphological test to identify the
452 class of two-place predicates. Regardless of the basic verb valence, it is worth noticing
453 nevertheless that the predicates in Table 3 align with some of the properties that Say (2021:
454 182) describes as characteristics of natural antipassives, including the types of verbs that
455 typically undergo antipassivization (see, the verb hierarchy proposed by Malchukov 2015).
456 Semantically, predicates in their basic form cover a large range of verb classes, including
457 not not only proper activities (‘greet’), but also contact (‘hit’), pursuit (‘search’), cognition
458 (‘know’, ‘remember’) and speaking verbs (‘ask’, ‘ask for’), among others. As noted earlier,
459 this verb list nicely illustrates that the base predicate typically includes a highly agentive A
460 argument and the derived predicate corresponds to an activity that highlights the agent’s
461 involvement in the event.

462 However, there are only a few two-place predicates that deviate from the general
463 derivational pattern associated with detransitivizing functions in agent foregrounding con-
464 structions. In particular, two-place predicates belonging to the class of ingestive verbs –
465 such as ‘eat’, ‘drink’, ‘smoke’, and ‘lick’ – only combine with *-gan* as a causativizer rather
466 than as a marker of the agent foregrounding construction. Recall that Mocoví is categorized
467 as transitivity language which strongly favors causativization of one-place predicates (see
468 ??).

- 469 (23) a. *so nogot=oki? Ø-ke?e-tak pan_{sp}*
DET₂ adolescent=DIM.M 3.II-eat₁-PROG bread
470 ‘The kid is eating bread.’ (mocCA160726: 00:03:02)
- 471 b. *Ø-ke?e-gan pan_{sp} so nogot=oki?*
3.II-eat₁-VM:TR bread DET₂ adolescent=DIM.M

472 ‘(The woman) fed bread to the kid.’ (mocCA160726: 00:33:17)

473 (24) a. *so jale mafi i-me-wek n-e?et-tape-gi na*
DET₂ man already 3.II-end-DIR:OUT 3.III-drink-PROG.PL-LOC₄ DET₃
474 *l-atar*
3.POSS-medicine

475 ‘The man already got better (because) he is taking his medicine.’

476 (mocCA160711_1: 00:43:17)

477 b. *n-e?et-gan*
3.III-drink-VM:TR

478 ‘S/he/it makes him/er drink it.’ (Buckwalter 1995: 115)

479 Typologically, it is not unusual for ingestive verbs to show idiosyncratic behavior with
480 respect to the valence alternation patterns they participate in and the transitivity profile of
481 the verb lexicon (see Nichols et al. 2004). In a typological survey on causative constructions
482 Dixon & Aikhenvald (2000: 63-65) concluded that “drinking and eating are the transitive
483 activities which people are most likely to make other people do, on every other continent”.
484 Similarly, for languages with an intransitive constraint on morphological causativization,
485 Næss (2009: 30-31) and Amberber (2009: 48-54) observed more recently that not only are
486 ‘eat’ and ‘drink’ flexible in terms of causativization, but so are “other verbs referring to acts
487 of ingestion or consumption”, e.g. ‘smoke’ and ‘lick’, as well as verbs of perception, e.g.
488 ‘know’.

489 Lastly, given that the main focus of agent foregrounding constructions is the agent’s
490 activity, it naturally follows that the animacy of the demoted P argument is not a relevant
491 parameter of variation. Typological work has shown that the animacy of demoted P ar-
492 guments plays a role in the variation observed in antipassives (Say 2021, Zúñiga & Kittilä
493 2019). However, the list of predicates in Table 3 and the examples discussed so far show
494 that both animate and inanimate referents can serve as implied demoted P arguments, al-
495 though one or the other may be semantically more appropriate depending on the predicate.
496 For example, an animate P argument is implied with predicates such as *-kin* ‘greet’ or *-lar*
497 ‘send/order’, while an inanimate participant is more suitable with predicates such as
498 *-qawalat* ‘knead’ or *-pelog* ‘rake’. Other predicates allow both animate and inanimate P
499 arguments depending on the discourse context, such as *-tfaq* ‘cut’ or *-lat* ‘leave’. Finally,
500 note that the distribution of the two agent foregrounding markers cannot be determined
501 by the animacy of the P argument, since both animate and inanimate referents may appear
502 in *-gan* and *-takan* detransitivized constructions.

4.1 Lexicon building interaction

Another relevant fact about the verb markers *-gan* and *-takan* is their crucial role in the creation of derived lexical items from verbal sources. Morphologically derived nouns of different types often require a change in the valence profile of the base predicate before undergoing category change via nominalizers. In this section, I illustrate how valence change works in tandem with what [Gualdieri \(1998: 150-153\)](#) defined as agent nominalization morphology.

- (25) *?we ka i-wa:n-gan-gak*
EXIST DET₁ 1SG.POSS-see-VM:INTR-NMLZ.ACT
'... (and) I have a vision (for the future) ...' (mocCA190924_1: 00:05:58)
- (26) *ka-i-ra ra i-a?gat-gan-gak na na?ga*
DET₁-i-DET₄ DET₄ 1SG.POSS-speak-VM:INTR-NMLZ.ACT DET₃ day
'...these are my words today...' (mocCA190924_1: 00:07:00)
- (27) *?we so ra l-e:nat-gan-gak*
EXIST DET₂ DET₃ 3.POSS-ask-VM:INTR-NMLZ.ACT
'...he had questions (today)...' (mocCA180709: 00:09:05)

Building on the valence restrictions for the selection of *-gan* or *-takan* described above, detransitivized predicates create a new base on which the nominalizer *-gak* operates, as shown in (25)–(27). As in typical lexical nominalization processes, the core arguments of the derived predicates are recategorized as participants within the nominal domain. In particular, the subject/agent becomes the possessor of the derived noun. Semantically, it is not arbitrary that *-gan* is selected in the creation of derived nouns of this type, as they denote abstract entities corresponding to the action carried out by the possessor. The nominalization process overrides any implication of the demoted P argument, which explains why the possessor is the only remaining participant.

5 Discourse distribution: a case study

One aspect that has not received much attention in relation to agent foregrounding constructions concerns their discourse distribution. This section therefore examines the actual occurrence of *-gan* and *-takan* in natural speech. The goal is purely descriptive: to determine how frequent the different types of agent foregrounding predicates are in discourse, and to identify any correspondence between predicate types and the expression of P arguments (for a similar example, see [Haude & Allasonnière-Tang 2023](#)). Although these

532 questions are basic, such a quantitative investigation has not previously been carried out
 533 for valence-changing operations in Mocoví or in other Guaycuruan languages. There are,
 534 however, relevant studies on related topics, such as counts of lexical argument expression
 535 in Mocoví (see Califa 2014) and Chaco Toba's discourse (see Cúneo & Messineo 2019).

536 The case study presented here is based on a single narrative discourse, used as a
 537 first step to complement the qualitative observations on the distribution and function of
 538 agent foregrounding constructions. The narrative has the characteristics of a monologue,
 539 in which the speaker recalls various past and present life events. Building on the clause
 540 types and patterns of argument expression described in ??, each clause is annotated accord-
 541 ing to the following parameters: (i) predicate meaning, (ii) valence type, (iii) P-argument
 542 expression, and (iv) the type of expression used for the P argument. An additional param-
 543 eter is applied only to third-person P arguments, identifying the determiner type used in
 544 nominal P-argument expressions. This variable is intended to capture whether some of
 545 the semantic properties encoded by nominal determiners show a correspondence with the
 546 types of P-argument expressions attested in discourse.

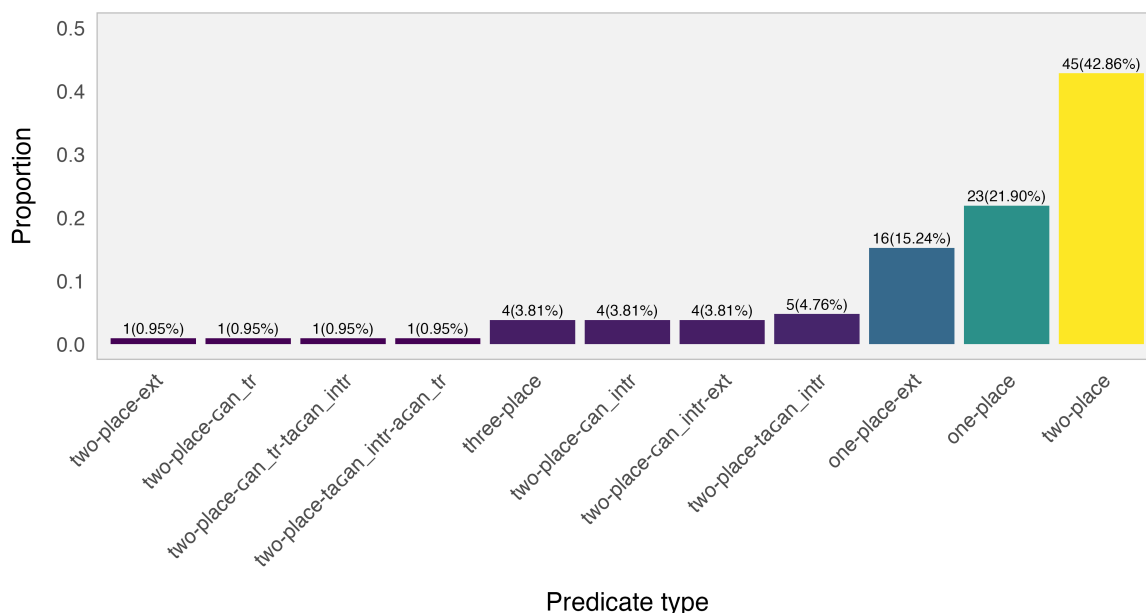


Figure 3: Proportion of predicates in natural discourse (values on each bar represent individual counts and percentages).

547 Figure 3 shows the proportions of predicates according to their valence type. The
 548 labels on the x-axis indicate whether the predicate is morphologically basic or derived. If
 549 predicates are double-derived via *-can* or *-tacan*, the order and function of the derivational
 550 elements follow the same order represented in the labels. Thus, a two-place predicate may

551 be detransitivized by *-takan* and then transitivized again by *-gan*, a sequence captured by
 552 the label *two-place-takan_intr-gan_tr*.

553 As for the the proportion of predicates, basic one-place and two-place predicates are
 554 more frequent than the morphologically derived predicates. In contrast, predicates that
 555 include *-gan* or *-takan* in their agent foregrounding function occur with low frequency.
 556 Similarly, predicates that combine the transitivizing function of *-gan* with spatial morphol-
 557 ogy – thus extending the number of participants encoded by the predicate – also appear
 558 infrequently in discourse. Table 4 lists all predicates participating in the *-gan* / *-takan* verb
 559 alternation, confirming the tokens found in the larger list presented earlier in Table 3.

count	verb_in_sentence	predicate_type	n
1	speak	two-place-gan_intr-ext	4
2	know	two-place-takan_intr	3
3	work	two-place-gan_intr	2
4	ask_for_permission	two-place-gan_intr	1
5	eat	two-place-gan_tr	1
6	eat	two-place-gan_tr-takan_intr	1
7	know	two-place-takan_intr-agan_tr	1
8	remember	two-place-takan_intr	1
9	speak	two-place-gan_intr	1
10	transfer_knowledge	two-place-takan_intr	1

Table 4: Predicates occurring in the *-gan* or *-takan* verb alternations.

560 As mentioned in previous sections, there is variation in whether the P argument of
 561 agent foregrounding constructions is expressed or not. Table 5 illustrates this variation.
 562 Although the sample is small, the variation is still observable at the discourse level. Note
 563 that all instances of derived predicates in which the final derivational element corresponds
 564 to the intransitivizing function of *-gan* or *-takan* include cases where the demoted P ar-
 565 gument is absent. In contrast, when *-gan* functions as a transitivizing element or when
 566 argument-extension morphology is involved, the P argument is present.

count	predicate_type	P_present	P_absent
1	two-place-gan_intr-ext	4	0
2	two-place-tagan_intr	2	3
3	two-place-gan_intr	1	3
4	two-place-tagan_intr-agan_tr	1	0
5	two-place-gan_tr	1	0
6	two-place-gan_tr-tagan_intr	0	1

Table 5: Occurrence of presence and absence of P arguments in *-gan* or *-tagan* derived predicates.

Looking at the three instances in which agent foregrounding constructions co-occur with a P argument, we can observe that the discourse contexts involve predicates that highlight the agent’s activity, a reading reinforced by the low referentiality of the demoted argument. In (28), for example, the detransitivized predicate is followed by an object complement-like clause whose predication can be interpreted as an abstract reference to the types of things a teacher teaches. Similarly, (29) involves an indefinite nominal P argument within a nominal structure that is preceded by the indefinite nominal *na?we* ‘all’.

(28) *s-a?den-q-ta* *so-?e* *maestro_{sp}* *r-apagin-tagan* *ka*
1.II-know-PL-DUR DET₂-? teacher 3II.INTR-transfer_knowledge-VM:INTR DET₁
sa-s-a?den-q *qomir* *i-a?de:n-tagan-gan-er*
NEG1.II-know-PL 1PL.PRON 3.II-know-VM:INTR-VM:TR-PL
‘...we know (what a) teacher (does), he teaches what we don’t know, (he) makes us
to know (or he instructs us)...’ (mocCA190924_1: 00:04:27)

(29) *s-o?wenat-agan-tak* *na?we-na-he* *n-owenat-ek*
1.II-work-VM:INTR-PROG all-DET₅-? INDET.POSS-work-NMLZ.OBJ.SG
‘...(now) I keep working on any kind of jobs...’ (mocCA190924_1: 00:03:48)

6 Conclusions and outlook

This study has analyzed agent foregrounding constructions in Northern Chaco Mocoví and their effects on the expression of core arguments in basic and derived two-place predicates. It argues that agent foregrounding constructions, morphologically marked by *-gan* or *-tagan*, primarily indicate the high prominence of the agent-like argument, while secondarily affecting the expression of the P argument, which may be omitted, expressed as a bare noun, or marked as an oblique. Semantically, these strategies of P-argument demotion

typically involve low definiteness and low discourse referentiality of the demoted nominal referents. Importantly, the paper also shows that the language employs multiverbal constructions to reintroduce the originally demoted P argument by repeating verb roots with identical semantics. This type of multiverbal strategy does not appear to be widespread cross-linguistically and therefore warrants further typological research.

The lexical distribution of -gan and -tagan shows a complementary and asymmetrical pattern: most predicates participating in agent foregrounding are two-place verbs, and -gan is considerably more frequent than -tagan. These observations align with typological work on antipassive-like constructions and illustrate the semantic constraints that shape valence alternation in the language.

The study also highlights the importance of agent foregrounding in lexicon building. The detransitivized predicate provides the base for several derived nouns, particularly those denoting abstract entities associated with an agent's activity. The nominalization process incorporates the agent as the possessor while eliminating reference to the demoted P argument, showing how valence alternation interacts with lexical derivation.

Finally, the discourse-based analysis shows that agent foregrounding constructions are relatively infrequent but occur in specific functional contexts. When they appear, they contribute to the structuring of narrative information, especially by emphasizing the agent's action and reducing the referential prominence of the P argument. These findings open a promising line of research for future work on valence-changing mechanisms in Mocoví and related Guaycuruan languages, as well as for broader typological investigations of antipassives and argument demotion.

7 Supplementary material

- The complete project including the raw data, annotation and code for data processing is in the following public repository <https://github.com/JuarezRC/p-demotion-project.git>
- The natural discourse analyzed in this work is part of the open access audiovisual collection *Documentation and Description of Northern Chaco Mocoví* (Juárez 2019). Access to the raw audio, video and pictures of the recording session are available here https://www.elararchive.org/uncategorized/SO_9538d856-a984-491d-87c1-86ab9ed2ce74/

Abbreviations

619	*	ungrammatical	646	EXCLAM	exclamation
620	sp	Spanish loanword	647	EXIST	existential
621	1	first person	648	F	feminine
622	2	second person	649	I	Set I bound person form
623	3	third person	650	II	Set II bound person form
624	ACT	action	651	III	Set III bound person form
625	ADV	adverbial	652	IN	inwards
626	ARG	argument	653	INDET	indeterminate
627	ATTR	attributive	654	INTR	intransitive
628	CAUS	causative	655	INTS	intensifier
629	CAUSEE	causee argument	656	LOC ₂	locative type 2
630	COLL	collective	657	LOC ₃	locative type 3
631	DEFC	defocusing	658	LOC ₄	locative type 4
632	DES	desiderative	659	M	masculine
633	DET	determiner	660	NEG	negative
634	DET ₁	determiner type 1: non-visible	661	NMLZ	nominalizer
635	DET ₂	determiner type 2: going, far	662	OBJ	object
636	DET ₃	determiner type 3: coming, close	663	OBL	oblique
637	DET ₄	determiner type 4: static, vertical	664	OUT	outwards
638	DET ₅	determiner type 5: static, horizontal	665	PL	plural
639		tal	666	POSS	possessive
640	DET ₆	determiner type 6: static, sitting	667	PROG	progressive
641	DIM	diminutive	668	PRON	pronominal
642	DIR	directional	669	SBJ	subject
643	DISC	discourse maker	670	SG	singular
644	DOWN	downwards	671	TR	transitive
645	DUR	durative	672	VM	valence modifier

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